

Dynamics

The terms and symbols in music that indicate the quietness or loudness of a sound are called dynamics. While notated, they are relative and somewhat subject to a performer's interpretation.

Dynamic terms and symbols

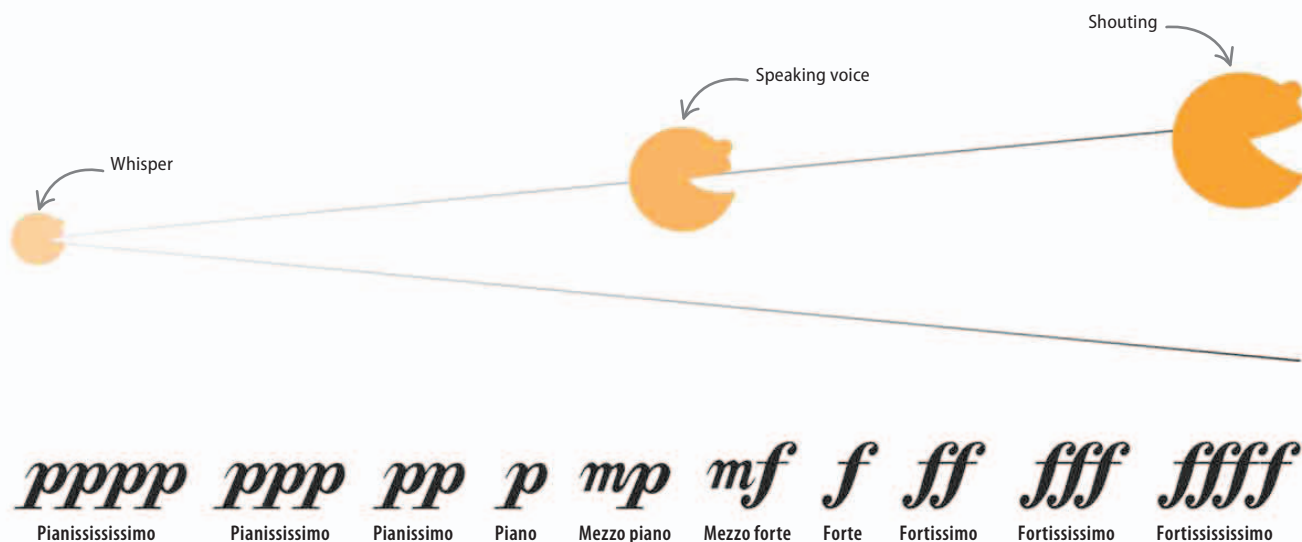
Like many musical expressions, dynamic markings are traditionally provided in Italian. Shown here is a list of the most commonly used dynamic terms, from quietest to loudest. There is often not enough room to note the entire dynamic term in a musical score, so the accompanying symbols are frequently used to denote each dynamic level.

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▽ Dynamic markings

This shows the relationship between typical sounds you might make to illustrate dynamic levels, ranging from very quiet (*pppp*), to medium (*mf*), all the way to very loud (*ffff*).



GLOSSARY

Sforzando

This marking instructs the performer to play loud, and then suddenly quiet. Different instruments achieve this in various ways: wind musicians initiate the tone harshly, with lots of air and a hard attack, and then dramatically drop breath support.

sfz

◁ **Sforzando**
Abbreviated *sfz*,
sforzando, is Italian
for "forced."

Musicians and genre determine what **dynamic markings** sound like in a particular piece: a **brass quintet** playing its **quietest** will still be **louder** than a **solo flute**.